Essay for the Department of Languages, Literature and Cultures

This is an essay assignment for a second-year module on Questions of Translation and Transcultural Communication. Students need to write a **2000-2400** word essay referring to at least TWO theorists or theories and illustrate their answer with examples from translations they are familiar with.

For first class work, markers are looking for a 'well-planned, clear and compelling overall argument. The introduction is rich and thought-provoking, and helpfully outlines the trajectory of the ensuing argument; the body of the argument is well structured and clear, with no elements seeming out of place or unjustified, and the conclusion is rich, nuanced, and offers a provisional answer to the question while gesturing towards wider issues.' Also the work needs to fully acknowledge 'a range of sources through quotations and paraphrase, always appropriately and correctly referenced. Quotations are accurate and are smoothly integrated into the syntax of sentences. The bibliography is complete, wide-ranging, and accurate.'

MARKER'S COMMENTS

Overall, a very good essay.

Strengths:

- This is a very well-structured essay that presents a well-planned overall argument.
- I really appreciate your ability to balance your opinion and scholarly discourse: it shows critical skills and intellectual independence.
- You show a competent knowledge of the theoretical reading, and your essay is written in a consistent and mature academic register and expression.

Areas for further development:

- Discuss assertions in more detail: e.g.: you state that 'translations play a significant role in shaping perceptions and attitudes about diverse cultures and languages' - here you could explain why that is the case and why unethical translations on the other hand perpetuate stereotypes. It might also help to have an example that you analyse to prove this point.
- The different examples for ethical awareness could be connected a bit clearer (think about the transition from one theoretical perspective to the next).
- Referencing can be improved. You need to also use references when you paraphrase, and you should use separate quotation marks for quotes and emphasis. The bibliography needs some restructuring: It should be in alphabetical order and all the sources should use the same style.

‘The best translators are the most ethically aware translators.’

Ethics are (or at least, should be) extremely important in any occupation, as they help build a sense of belonging to it. Additionally at the same time, the premise and certainty of ethics in some specific professional groups increase social trust. They are vital (and by law, obligatory) in the case of a job such as one of a doctor, but many other professionals also have to ensure their ethics in order to perform their functions. One of the less obvious examples would be a sworn translator who receives a number of secret documents for inspection and must maintain confidentiality. Disclosure of the information received would mean breaking the rules of professional ethics and, due to that, legal consequences would inevitably follow, i.e., not being authorized to practice the profession anymore. However, if being ethically aware while practicing such occupation was not mandated by law, would it be worth it? Would it affect one’s work in a noticeable, major way? There are some, that can prove that the best translators are the most ethically aware translators, meaning that they have a deep understanding of the ethical considerations and implications of their work. In this essay, I will examine the importance of ethical awareness in translation and the potential consequences of unethical translations.

Here is a classically constructed introduction moving from a wide-angle view of the topic to a sharp, close-up focus on essay purpose.

There are several reasons why ethical awareness is so significant in terms of translations. Firstly, all translators are responsible for conveying the meaning of the source text in a way that is accurate, appropriate, and respectful to all parties involved. That involves sensitivity to cultural and linguistic differences, avoiding the use of (even potentially) offensive or discriminatory language, as well as ensuring that translations are appropriate for the intended audience. Secondly, translations can often have consequences outside of their own profession, particularly in fields such as legal, medical, or tied to governments. Inaccurate or inappropriate translations in the aforementioned environments could, more often than not, lead to serious miscommunication, legal issues, and even many more risks. Thirdly, translations play a significant role in shaping perceptions and attitudes about diverse cultures and languages. Unethical translations can perpetuate stereotypes, cause misunderstandings and even be a vessel of discrimination, as all translated works are, in a way, vessels of communication with audiences from diverse backgrounds, cultures, countries.

As the marker notes, this claim could benefit from more explanation – perhaps with the help of an example.

Laurence Venuti, an American translation theorist and historian mentions the inherent “unfairness” being ingrained in every translation. He claims that “asymmetries, inequities, relations of domination and dependence exist in every act of translating, of putting the translated in the service of the translating culture. Translators are complicit in the institutional

exploitation of foreign texts and cultures.[1]". It is indisputable that his evaluation of the overall, usual translating process results in a negative rating. I believe "contributing to exploitation", of which Venuti accuses translators is unequivocally unethical. He illustrates his argument with the story of an Argentine writer Jorge Luis Borges and the translator of his work. In the 1960s and 1970s, Norman Thomas di Giovanni assisted Borges by publishing several English-language versions of his fiction and poetry, acting as his literary agent, and "helping" to establish his canonical status. However, di Giovanni's translation process involved significant revisions to make the works more accessible to an American audience, by conforming to American stylistic standards and simplifying the language. That approach also resulted in the suppression of the unique literary qualities of Borges's writing and can be seen as an anti-intellectual approach to translating a highly intellectual writer. We can therefore conclude that Di Giovanni was not the best translator due to his lack of ethics awareness. Due to his complete disregard of the source text, his text conveyed something completely different than the original, which in a way was very unfair to the target readers, who would believe they were reading the works of Jorge Luis Borges. In reality, they were unknowingly denied access to it, whether in terms of its message, style, or originality. Translators do ought to make their source texts more accessible, but only by allowing more people (target readers) to access what they convey and of what they are composed. It is not their job, nor do they have the right, to make it into something their "audience" might be more used to. That is the reason why that behaviour was truly unethical not only to the target readers, but the original author too. At the international level, Jorge Luis Borges' uniqueness, self-expression and authorial intention, a product of his own demanding work and time, were simply stripped away from him. His canonical status, which Di Giovanni helped establish, did not truly belong to him in a sense. When it came to Di Giovanni's target readers, Borges' text was, on a fundamental level, erased, as it possessed none of his originality, or any of the differences (in terms of linguistics or culture) that a foreign work ought to contain. Moreover, it can also be a testament to the translator's expertise, whether they possess the skill to make the target text accessible to their target readers without depriving the source text (and its author) of its nuances, which was the case of the aforementioned translation.

Here the writer does use an example case (the translation of Borges) to support an argument.

This concluding point is well made but the preceding discussion could be a little more concise.

The phenomenon of exploitation occurring in translations was not something that only Venuti would notice. Serge Gavronsky, American poet,

[1] Venuti, Lawrence. *The Scandals of Translation: Towards an Ethics of Difference*, (Taylor & Francis Group, 1998), p. 4

and translator, compares that process to an "oedipal structure" [2]. He compares the relationship between the translator and the author (with the source text) to one of a child with his father, who at the same time is his rival. He argues that that the translator (the former) manipulating and altering (tampering with) the text, at least partially eliminates the father's authority and dominance. In terms of authorship and originality of the work the "paternal figure" becomes dependent upon the "child", and converts into a subordinate, his subject of sorts. Gavronsky even goes as far to accuse the translator of truly despicable actions, as for him he represents a male who "repeats on the sexual level the kinds of crimes any colonizing country commits on its colonies". To Gavronsky, translation is akin to the power of male privilege, exercised in family and state political arenas. However, even though he pictures the image of a translator to be comparable to such a heinous, unethical (to say the least) figure, he also proposes a counterpart that is their absolute opposite. The other translator, despite also supposedly being a man, is modest, non-violent, and even "takes a vow of chastity". Although the hierarchy where the author of the source text comes after the translator is very much present in both of the metaphorical relationships, one of them is clearly morally superior. According to Gavronsky, a translator who is not considerate of the "virtue" of the original creator (and their creation) is unethical, which makes him no better than a cruel, evil character. While the submissiveness of the author seems inevitable, the detail of that compliance being wilful (ethical) can put it "next to godliness".

Reference needed.

A useful account of Gavronsky's view of translation that might be strengthened further by evaluation i.e., exploring the strengths and weaknesses of his view.

Being ethically aware in terms of translation can manifest itself in a variety of other ways though. Emily Wilson stands out among translators due to her openly feminist approach, as well as becoming the first woman who published a translation of Homer's Odyssey into English (2017). She raises awareness about how a topic as important as gender inequality has been overlooked repeatedly in translations, especially when it comes to androcentric texts like the *Odyssey*[3]. Wilson is one of very few who took it upon themselves to step up and provide target readers with an accurate overview of this ancient-old issue of misogyny that still keeps prevailing in society to this day. She also stated that her approach is to refrain from introducing modern forms of sexism into the ancient poem, and instead focus on highlighting the specific forms of sexism and patriarchy issues that despite being present in the source texts, can only be partially recognizable nowadays, in contemporary society[4]. Her ethical awareness is what makes

Nice transition sentence.

[2] *TRANSLATION STUDIES READER*, (edited by Lawrence Venuti, Taylor & Francis Group, 2012), p. 259

[3] Emily Wilson, 'Epilogue', *Homer's Daughters: Women's Responses to Homer in the Twentieth Century and Beyond*, (ed. Fiona Cox and Elena Theodorakopolous), 2019, p. 202

[4] Emily Wilson, in Homer: Odyssey, trans. Emily Wilson (2017), p. 89

her work so distinguishable and extraordinary. Not only does she completely respect the authorship by not changing any actual content of the source texts, but she also makes sure that the issues present there are included in the target texts as well. That is especially notable since the matters of sexism are (unfortunately) still controversial in today's world. The bias of other translators causes their work to not only be a vessel of discrimination (by overlooking women and issues which directly affect them), but also misinformation. The aforementioned *Odyssey* makes it clear how that type of bias can wrongly convey (or perhaps, purposely change) the meaning of the text. This can be exemplified by comparing Wilson's work with the versions created by e.g.: A.T. Murray (Loeb Classical Library) or A.V. Rieu (Penguin). While the narratives of the latter two make women's roles appear diminished, Wilson makes sure to make their value clear. In the former, Odysseus is described as forming a plan, while Athene is added merely as his "aid", an afterthought. In the latter, however, they can be seen as equal, as they are depicted as devising a scheme together ("Odysseus stayed in the hall, still plotting with Athena how to destroy the suitors[5]"). In the very next sentence, another example of Wilson's distinguishable approach can be seen standing out; she puts a noticeably clear emphasis on Penelope's wits, focusing less on her physical appearance or comparison to others ("Then the queen, her wits about her, came down from her room, like Artemis or Aphrodite[6]"). Wilson not only managed to keep the original, intended meaning, she makes sure women are duly, properly represented, which is obviously more ethical than omitting them or their values due to personal bias, which is in turn perpetuating discrimination.

This paragraph provides a positive model of ethical translation well-evidenced by analysis of the exemplary work of Emily Wilson.

Furthermore, translating without proper ethical awareness might affect the outside world in an even more major (negative) ways. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, an Indian scholar and literary theorist, was the one to recognize the dire consequences of that, especially when it came to translating works from Third World Countries into English, which out of all languages holds the most power in the world, being the main tool of globalization. These include erasing the voices and perspectives of less powerful individuals and cultures, spreading an ideologically motivated image of colonized people, and reinforcing stereotypes through the rewriting of the image of "the East" by colonial powers. Additionally, the incorporation of source cultures into the target culture through translation can be seen as cultural appropriation. One solution to the issues is the use of prefaces, translator's notes, and interviews with the author. These added elements provide context and insight into the original text and its cultural origins, allowing for a more nuanced and authentic representation. Additionally, Spivak advocates for the approach of "Translation as Intimate Reading" where the translator must "surrender to the text" in order to fully understand and accurately convey the meaning and cultural significance.

Reference needed when summarising ideas from a source.

[5, 6] Emily Wilson, in Homer: Odyssey, trans. Emily Wilson (2017)

This approach prioritizes a deep engagement and understanding of the source text over the imposition of the translator's own perspective. By implementing these solutions, the translation process can become a more equitable and respectful representation of the source culture.

Clear summary of Spivak's view of translation.

An ethically aware translator is not only essential for ensuring the quality and accuracy of translations, but also for fostering mutual understanding and respect between distinct cultures and languages. In today's modern, globalized world, translation plays a crucial role in facilitating communication and understanding between them. As such, the role of the translator is not just to convey the meaning of words from one language to another, but also to ensure that the translations are accurate, appropriate, and respectful to all parties involved. While ethical awareness can manifest itself in a wide variety of ways as aforementioned, it all comes down to morality (if not decency) and recognizing the honour of translating.
Word Count: 2040

A very strong conclusion that draws together all threads and also looks beyond the confines of the essay question to broader implications.

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